

arms, were fitted somewhere near the facing point in each direction. The “outer” signals were really just warning indicators for forthcoming stop signals to help the driver control the speed. The two types of signals worked in tandem. The placement of signals, however, was not uniform. For instance, on the Bombay, Baroda and Central India (BB&CI) Railway sections, the “main” signals existed at both ends of the station and the “outer” signals were pushed further away. On the other hand, on the Madras Railway, the “main signals” were erected near the facing points. Signals at the end of the stations are sometimes also called “starter” signals.

Towards the end of the 19th century and the beginning of the 20th, there were revisions to signalling practices with regard to equipment. Initially, a rule indicated that all “distant” signals had to have an additional fishtailed arm. These were also changed to absolute stop signals. There were more improvisations over the years, which included adding a green light to the fishtailed arm and removing the square-ended arm.

Absolute block system

Earlier trains worked under the absolute block system, on the premise that the section between two particular stations, called the block section, should be clear for a train to leave from one station to another. Fortunately, by the time railways made their way to India, the world had already witnessed the use of electric telegraphs, which meant that the block system relied on the Morse Telegraph Instrument to transmit information on the line and whether it was safe to proceed. Once the driver received the line clear information, he received the “Paper Line Clear Ticket”, which functioned as an authority pass allowing him to proceed to the next station.

Improved block instruments aided by electricity were introduced subsequently. For instance, the East Indian Railway (EIR) and Great Indian Peninsula Railway (GIPR) used the Neale’s Ball token instruments on their single lines. This meant that electromechanical instruments dispensed metal balls as “tokens”, such that a single token could be issued for one direction at a time. On the Madras Railway, a